

Creating a Chat Application in App Inventor 2

As we move on in our journey of creating mobile applications using Google's App Inventor2, let's try out a chat app. Our expert guides the reader in creating a demo chat application that can be refined and modified later.



Chat is the trendy feature on smartphones nowadays. It is more interactive compared to the traditional SMS. Chatting on a smartphone allows you to create a group comprising friends or relatives and then talk to everyone in that group, simultaneously. We see this in most popular chat applications like Whatsapp, Facebook Messenger, Hike, etc.

Since there's been a lot of interest and enthusiasm among our readers to learn Android app development with App Inventor, we thought of exploring a new advanced topic. In the previous tutorial, we created a Web database using the open source cloud enabled Firebase database. In this tutorial, we will use our previous knowledge to deliver a fully working chat application.

For those who have missed the last tutorial, I would like to go over a few things quickly.

In our application, we are going to use the Firebase cloud database provided by Google, which is open source and freely available.

Features of Firebase

1. Firebase uses a GUI based data centre so that you can visually see and manage all the entries.
2. Being on the cloud, it is accessible on the go to any device.
3. Smart authentication provides secure access.
4. Being a real-time database, it reflects changes as soon as the data is updated.
5. Users can add collaborators, so that multiple people can manage the database.
6. There is no coding for fetching and storing data.

Creating a project in the Firebase database

1. To use Firebase, you need a working Google account, which is also needed to run App Inventor.
2. Type <https://console.firebase.google.com/> in the address bar of the browser you are using and hit *Enter*.

3. If login credentials are asked for, give your Google account credentials and proceed.
4. Follow the on-screen instructions, which generally ask you to accept the terms of usage.
5. Once everything is done, you will see the screen depicted in Figure 1.
6. Click on the 'Create New Project' button as shown in Figure 1.
7. Give the name of the project and country/region, as shown in Figure 2.
8. Once your project has been created, you will see the dashboard of your application, which will be similar to Figure 3.
9. Now select 'Database' from the left hand palette and then 'Rules' from the next page. It will display something like what's shown in Figure 4.
10. At this point, we want to give all users access to the database; hence, we need to change the rules. You can manually change the rules by typing values, as shown in Figure 5. Once done, click on the *Publish* button. You have now successfully created